Asper Business Case Competition 2027

Team Briefing: Format, Rules and Deliverables

Prof. Dr. Christoph Weisser

HSBI

Winnipeg, February 18–22, 2027

Table of Contents

1. The Competition at a Glance
2. Competition Format
3. Deliverables Before the Competition
4. Rules and Judging
5. Our Team and Roadmap

Overview

1. The Competition at a Glance
2. Competition Format
3. Deliverables Before the Competition
4. Rules and Judging
5. Our Team and Roadmap

What is the ABCC?

Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC)

A three-day, graduate-level business case competition hosted by the I. H. Asper School of Business, University of Manitoba, in Winnipeg, Canada. The 2027 edition (February 18–22) is the **fifth annual** competition.

- Hosted at the **Drake Centre**, 181 Freedman Crescent, University of Manitoba campus
- Teams from top Canadian business schools – and, since 2026, international teams
- 2026 field: 9 graduate teams, incl. HEC Montréal, DeGroote, Beedie, Babeș-Bolyai (Romania)

Why It Matters for Us

- First-hand experience with the **North American case method** under time pressure
- Benchmarking against strong Canadian MBA/graduate teams – the 2025 field included Ivey, John Molson, HEC Montréal, Telfer, DeGroote, Beedie, Levene, Memorial and Asper
- In 2026, the international newcomer Babeș-Bolyai University **won** the competition – international teams can absolutely compete for the title
- Rich social program: team-bonding events, networking with judges from industry, gala dinner with awards

Scale of the event (2026)

35 participants, 9 faculty advisors, 50 industry judges, 52 volunteers.

Team Composition and Eligibility

- Teams consist of **four students**; all four present in every round
- Open to graduate-level students (full-time, part-time, executive MBA, and Masters-level students of other management programs)
- Each team travels with a **faculty advisor / coach** (that is me)
- Maximum of four laptops per team; **no cellphones or smartwatches** during case preparation and presentations

Golden rule

Every team member must speak in every presentation and discussion round; judging uses the official 7-category team rubric.

Overview

1 The Competition at a Glance

2 Competition Format

3 Deliverables Before the Competition

4 Rules and Judging

5 Our Team and Roadmap

A Typical Competition Week (2025 Schedule Pattern)

Day	Programme	Evening
Wednesday	Arrival, registration, division draw	Free
Thursday	**Prepared case** presentations	Museum social event
Friday	**Boardroom case**: 4 h prep + presentations	Festival du Voyageur
Saturday	**Traditional case**: 3 h prep + presentations	Finals, gala & awards
Sunday	Departure	–

- Teams present in staggered slots (division draw at registration); shuttles provided
- 2027 daily agenda still **TBA**. Both documented editions ran **Wednesday–Sunday** (2025: Wed Feb 19 – Sun Feb 23; 2026: Wed Feb 18 – Sat Feb 21, departure Sunday), but the published 2027 window Feb 18–22 falls **Thursday–Monday** – the first Thursday start in the series
- So either the window is exact (registration Thu, gala Sun, departure Mon) or the real week is **Wed Feb 17 – Sun Feb 21**. We plan to the published dates and fly an envelope that covers both

Three Rounds, Three Different Styles

Round	Prep time	Format	Weight
1: Prepared case	ca. 2 weeks (before travel)	25 min + 15 min Q&A	25 %
2: Boardroom case	short (4 h in 2026)	3 min + 22 min discussion	30 %
3: Traditional case	short (3 h in 2026)	20 min + 10 min Q&A	45 %

- Escalating difficulty and point value across the three rounds
- Top 3 teams advance to a **final round** in front of a new judge panel
- Ties broken by the highest traditional-case score

Round 1: The Prepared Case

Format

25-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A. Unlimited slides and exhibits. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- Case is released **weeks before the competition** – worked on at home
- A real client: in 2026 this was **Jazz Winnipeg** (pitch a radical new operational idea)
- All resources may be used – **except** contacting employees of the case sponsor
- The coach **may** give input on this case (unlike rounds 2 and 3)
- Slide deck must be **submitted before the deadline** – late submissions are placed at the bottom of the pool

Round 2: The Boardroom Case

Format

Seated boardroom setting: 3-minute uninterrupted recommendation, then 22 minutes of open discussion with the judges (in 2026: four judges plus a company representative).

- Short preparation window on site (4 hours in 2025 and 2026)
- Protected 3 minutes: **one summary slide only** – appendices are blocked; red card at 1 minute
- Appendices unlocked for the 22-minute discussion (yellow/red cards at 5/1 minutes)
- Judges receive a **one-page black-and-white brief** in advance; deck + brief handed in on a provided USB stick
- Seated delivery via wireless keyboard/mouse; **no coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Coal & Canary – elevate the brand from premium to luxury

Round 3: The Traditional Case

Format

Classic case-competition style: 20-minute presentation + 10-minute Q&A. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- Short preparation window on site (3 hours in 2026)
- Highest weight of all rounds: **45 %** of the total score
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches
- **No coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Access Credit Union – service innovations to engage young customers

The Final Round

- The **top 3 teams** present again before a fresh judge panel
- 20-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A
- Slide decks **cannot be modified** for the final
- Faculty advisors may not communicate with their team until after the presentation
- Winners announced at the **gala dinner**

2026 podium

1. Babeș-Bolyai University (Romania) 2. DeGroote School of Business 3. HEC Montréal

Overview

1 The Competition at a Glance

2 Competition Format

3 Deliverables Before the Competition

4 Rules and Judging

5 Our Team and Roadmap

What We Must Hand In Before the Competition

1. **Registration** of the school/team with the organizers (contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca – Judith Jayasuriya, Steven Harrison)
2. **Team roster**: four students + faculty advisor, with bios/photos as requested by the organizers
3. **Prepared-case slide deck** (Round 1): **.pptx only**, submitted by e-mail, file named "[Team Name] Prepared Case" – in 2025: released Feb 5, due Feb 19, 10:00 CT (registration day). Late = bottom of the pool
4. Any **forms and waivers** sent by the organizing committee after registration
5. Optional but smart: **prebuilt slide template** for the on-site rounds (explicitly allowed; build it in advance)

Note

The detailed 2027 agenda and exact deadlines are still marked TBA on the official site – they will be communicated after registration. We track them in the repository as they arrive.

Overview

1 The Competition at a Glance

2 Competition Format

3 Deliverables Before the Competition

4 Rules and Judging

5 Our Team and Roadmap

Core Rules Across All Rounds

- Competition language: **English**; presentations must be **PowerPoint (.pptx)** – no Prezi etc.
- All four team members must speak in every round (not necessarily during the protected 3 minutes of the boardroom pitch)
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches during prep and presentation
- No contact with the coach after release of the boardroom and traditional cases; on-site decks are collected on a provided USB stick at fixed pickup times
- Time warnings: yellow card at 5 minutes, red card at 1 minute; **late arrival = no extra time**
- Slide clickers are provided; volunteers monitor rule compliance

Fair Play, Anonymity and Allowed Tools

Disqualification risks

Revealing your **school of origin** to a judge at any point, or any coach communication during a presentation or Q&A, leads to **disqualification**. Teams compete under neutral letters (division draw at registration).

- **Internet use is allowed** during prep – including university databases and **Generative AI**
- Prebuilt **own** slide templates are permitted (built outside prep time); no third-party templates for the prepared case
- Never contact employees of a case sponsor; cases are confidential – no sharing or reproducing
- Dress code: **business professional** throughout competition days

Scoring and Tie-Breaking

Round	Weight
Prepared case	25 %
Boardroom case	30 %
Traditional case	45 %

- Rubric-based evaluation by panels of industry judges
- Ties resolved by highest traditional-case score, then by performance in the weighted rounds and individual rubric categories
- Strategic implication: **the short-prep rounds decide the competition** (75 % combined) – our training focuses accordingly

The Judging Rubric (Official, 2025 Event Guide)

Category	Weight
Implementation & resources	2.5×
Analysis	2.0×
Recommendation	2.0×
Communicating effectively	1.0×
Framing the problem	1.0×
Impact	1.0×
Measurement, risks & mitigation	1.0×

Training implication

Implementation & resources carries the highest weight (2.5×): every recommendation needs a concrete path – steps, owners, timeline, resources, and financials – not just a good idea.

Overview

1. The Competition at a Glance
2. Competition Format
3. Deliverables Before the Competition
4. Rules and Judging
5. Our Team and Roadmap

Playing to Our Strengths

Background	Natural lead role	Typical ownership
Finance	CFO of the team	Financials, valuation, sensitivity
Innovation	Creative lead	Idea generation, differentiation
Computer Science	Analytics/tech lead	Data, feasibility, digital angle
General Business	Strategist & integrator	Framing, structure, storyline

- Roles are **leads**, not silos – everyone masters the full storyline
- Rotating "presenter 1" role in practice so all four are strong openers

Preparation Roadmap (Details in the Prep Plan)

1. **Foundations** – case method, core frameworks, business math drills
2. **Skill building** – role-specific deep dives, slide craft, storylining
3. **Simulation** – weekly timed mock cases: 3 h traditional, 4 h boardroom
4. **Prepared case sprint** – structured 2-week sprint once Case 1 is released
5. **Final polish** – Q&A gauntlet, dress rehearsals, kit check

Guiding principle

Train hardest for what weighs most: short-prep cases under competition-identical time limits and device rules.

Sources and Further Information

- Official page: `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition`
- ABCC 2025 Event Guide (rules, rubric, schedule): `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-01/abcc25-eventguide.pdf`
- Past case PDFs 2024–2026 (all nine cases): linked in `01-competition/past_cases.md` of our repository
- 2026 recap: `https://umtoday.ca/stories/forging-worldwide-relationships-2026-asper-business-case-competition`
- Instagram: @Asper_BCC Contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca

Status of information

Rules and rubric follow the official 2025 Event Guide and the 2027 website; prep times and clients from 2025/2026. The 2027 agenda is TBA – re-verify all deadlines after registration.